

Ottawa Auto Theft Analysis Report

2018 – 2023

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Executive Summary

Car theft in Ottawa has reached crisis levels, rising **124.4%** over the five-year period from 2018 to 2023. On average, **four vehicles are stolen every day** across the city. In 2023 alone, the Ottawa Police Service recorded **1,994 stolen vehicles**, representing an estimated **\$26.6 million in loss value**, with only **57%** of those vehicles recovered.

This report analyzes auto theft trends across four dimensions — temporal patterns, geographical distribution, vehicle attributes, and recovery rates — and concludes with actionable recommendations for key stakeholders.

Auto theft data in this report covers all vehicle types, including cars, SUVs, trucks, motorcycles, vans, trailers, ATVs, snowmobiles, and motor homes.

Top priorities for reducing auto theft in Ottawa:

- 1. Preventing thefts through effective anti-theft measures by vehicle manufacturers.
- 2. Strengthening information sharing and data-driven partnerships among law enforcement and communities.

1. Temporal Analysis

Auto theft in Ottawa has followed a largely upward trajectory since 2018, reaching a record high in 2022 before a marginal decline in 2023.

Key Findings

Metric	Value
Total thefts, 2018–2023	7,826
Record high year	2022 (2,033 thefts)
YoY change, 2022–2023	-2.1%
Overall increase, 2018–2023	+123.8%
Peak months	October & November (~5 thefts/day)
Weekend share of thefts	26.3%
Evening/nighttime thefts (8 PM – 3 AM)	>58%

Analysis

Following the record high of **2,033 thefts in 2022**, Ottawa saw a slight year-over-year decrease of **2.1%** in 2023. Despite this, the overall trend since 2018 represents a **123.8% increase**, indicating a persistent and deepening problem.

Theft rates peak in **October and November**, reaching approximately five thefts per day. There is no strong seasonal pattern, though a dip is observed at the start of each year.

Weekdays account for the majority (**73.7%**) of thefts, suggesting that vehicles are more vulnerable during regular work and commute hours when owners may be less vigilant. However, the highest-risk time window is **evenings and nighttime (8 PM – 3 AM)**, which accounts for over **58%** of all thefts — with **40%** occurring specifically during evening hours.

2. Geographical Analysis

Theft activity is concentrated in residential areas in Ottawa's East and West divisions, with distinct patterns linked to proximity to export infrastructure.

Regional Theft Growth (2018–2023)

Division	Theft Increase
West Ottawa	+205.7%
East Ottawa	+139.2%
Central Ottawa	+30.9%

Key Findings

- **East Ottawa** reported the highest volume of thefts, accounting for over **41%** of all incidents. Its proximity to the **Port of Montreal** — a major hub for overseas vehicle exports — is a key contributing factor.
- **Barrhaven, Orleans, and Centretown** were the highest-risk neighbourhoods, with a combined estimated loss of approximately **\$17.7 million**.
- Theft density is highest in **densely populated residential neighbourhoods** in the East and West, while Central Ottawa — with its higher proportion of commercial activity — saw comparatively lower growth.

3. Vehicle Attributes

Organized crime groups are systematically targeting newer, higher-value vehicles for overseas resale, driving both theft volumes and financial losses.

Most Targeted Brands

Make	Share of Thefts	Notes
Toyota	21.8%	Most targeted; 2018/19/21/22 Highlander SUV most stolen model
Honda	Top 5	High combined loss value

Make	Share of Thefts	Notes
Ford	Top 5	High combined loss value
Jeep	Top 5	High combined loss value
Lexus	Top 5	High combined loss value

Honda, Ford, Jeep, and Lexus collectively represent a loss value of **\$36.6 million**.

Vehicle Age

- **52.9%** of stolen vehicles were manufactured in **2017 or newer**, representing **\$76.7 million** in total loss value.
- Newer vehicles are preferentially targeted by organized crime rings seeking maximum resale profit in overseas markets.
- The recovery rate for vehicles manufactured 2017 or newer is **50.9%**, suggesting a high proportion are being exported before recovery is possible.

Vehicle Type

- **Automobiles** (sedans, coupes, hatchbacks) were the most frequently stolen vehicle type, accounting for **58.7%** of all thefts.

4. Recovery Rates

Despite a modest year-over-year improvement in 2022–2023, the long-term trend in vehicle recovery rates is declining, pointing to increasingly sophisticated criminal operations.

Recovery Rate Trend

Year	Recovery Rate
2018	63.9%
2023	55.7%
Overall (2018–2023)	57.2%
YoY change (2022–2023)	+2.9%

Recovery Rate by Make (min. 200 reported thefts)

Make	Recovery Rate	Avg. Stolen Value	Interpretation
Hyundai	83.1%	~\$3,131	Likely stolen for use in other crimes, not resale
Lexus	40.2%	~\$13,170	Likely exported overseas by organized groups

- Of **483 stolen Lexus vehicles**, only **179** were recovered — a recovery rate of just **40.2%**.
- **Vehicles manufactured 2017 or newer** had a significantly lower recovery rate (**51.4%**) compared to older vehicles (**71.9%**), for models with at least 100 reported thefts.

- Toyota and Lexus, though among the most stolen brands, have disproportionately low recovery rates — underscoring the role of organized export operations and the need for enhanced tracking and anti-theft systems.
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5. Solutions and Recommendations

5.1 Enhanced Security in High-Risk Areas

Increase police and security presence in high-risk neighbourhoods — particularly in **East Ottawa** — during the peak theft window of **8 PM to 3 AM**. Targeted patrols in Barrhaven, Orleans, and Centretown should be prioritized.

5.2 Improved Vehicle Anti-Theft and Tracking Features

Engage automakers — particularly **Toyota, Honda, Ford, Jeep, and Lexus** — to:

- Address known security vulnerabilities exploited by criminal groups (e.g., relay attack weaknesses in keyless entry systems).
- Improve embedded vehicle tracking capabilities to support law enforcement recovery efforts.
- Implement stronger immobilization technology in high-demand models.

5.3 Community Awareness and Information Sharing

- Launch targeted awareness campaigns in high-risk neighbourhoods, focusing on theft prevention measures such as steering wheel locks, driveway cameras, and signal-blocking key pouches.
 - Strengthen data-sharing partnerships between the Ottawa Police Service, Transport Canada, the Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA), and Port of Montreal authorities to intercept export-bound stolen vehicles.
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Appendix

Coverage period: January 2018 – December 2023 **Data source:** Ottawa Police Service crime records **Vehicle types covered:** Cars, SUVs, trucks, motorcycles, vans, trailers, ATVs, snowmobiles, motor homes